License to Play

Linux gaming has for long been considered an oxymoron, but things change....

Linux! Say the word and you'll have most gamers running for cover. The truth is, gaming on Linux isn't as hard as most people think it is. In fact, there are even Linux LAN parties, mostly in the US and Europe of course. Here, we'll show you how to set up your favourite games on Linux.

The devil and the deep sea: Downloading installers

Most Linux installers, games or otherwise, are simple shell scripts that just have to be run at the command prompt to install software. These scripts are very complex beasts that can take care of every aspect of installing or un-installing, but the majority do not have a graphical interface—not really ideal for those used to 'Double-click > Next > Next > Next > Finish' installers.

To complicate things further, most browsers, Linux-based or not, cannot recognise the shell script as a program. After reading the first few lines of code, they decide that it's a text file instead. Even if you right-click and select 'Save as', the files are saved as HTML files. The only solution we could find was to use the ***'mv'*** command, and rename them to the original filename later.

The frying pan to the fire: Prerequisites

Like any other operating system, Linux too needs to be configured properly before you venture into the world of games. Some prerequisites are well configured graphics and sound cards, and installation of all the libraries (similar to DLLs in Windows), required to play a majority of the games. Luckily, most libraries required are already installed on your system; the ones that are not, will be covered in this workshop. As far as the configuration of the graphics and sound cards are concerned, they vary from vendor to vendor, but a few broad steps are outlined here.

In Linux, all devices are represented as special files under the '/dev/' filesystem. The sound and video devices are no exception. The audio device is represented as '/dev/dsp', while the graphics device is represented as a frame-buffer device. The frame-buffer device is an abstraction layer that provides a simple interface to the capabilities of the graphics hardware.

Although generic sound drivers are provided with the Linux kernel, several enhanced drivers are also available that can be easily incorporated into the operating system. Another important prerequisite is 3D accelerated drivers. The majority of the new games will not work with generic Linux distribution drivers. The best solution is to download the drivers for your specific graphics card from the vendor's Web site. In the case of nVidia, the latest drivers (NVIDIA-Linux-x86-1.0-4496-pkg2.run) can be downloaded from ***www.nvidia.com.*** Now, run the script from the command prompt. This will install the drivers in the right locations. These drivers have to be installed from the command prompt, after shutting down the GUI (X server). After installing the driver, you'll have to make a few changes to the '/etc/X11/XF86Config' file. Open the file using any text editor, scroll to the section 'Device', and change the driver from 'nv' to 'nvidia'. Now, restart the X server using the command ***'startx',*** or by rebooting into the Graphical mode.

If you have an ATi card, download the drivers from ***www.ati.com.*** These drivers are in rpm fromat, so use the ***'rpm -ivh'*** command to install them.

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